

A DEMONSTRATION CALLING FOR A FREEDOM FIGHTER'S PENSION SCHEME



Photographs by KRISHNA MURARI KISHAN

The Handout REVOLUTION

Activists of the 1974 JP Movement become eligible for a pension, worsening the Government's financial troubles

By Amitabh Srivastava

In 1972, on the eve of the 25th anniversary of Independence, the Centre introduced the Freedom Fighters Pension Scheme to honour the "courage, heroism, nobility of character and lofty ideas of thousands of workers who had faced suffering, privation and even death in their attempt to wrest freedom from an alien power". Thirty-eight years on, the Nitish Kumar Government in Bihar has announced a special pension plan for freedom fighters of another kind—those who participated in Jai Prakash Narayan's "Total Revolution Movement" of 1974 that ultimately led to the ouster of the

Indira Gandhi government in 1977. Both Nitish and Deputy Chief Minister Sushil Kumar Modi went to prison during the Emergency. So did Nitish's arch rival and RJD President Lalu Prasad Yadav and LJP chief Ram Vilas Paswan. Some who were jailed are now ministers in Bihar.

There is just one jarring irony—the pension funds belong to the taxpayers. The Rs 10-crore that has been pooled is good enough to build nearly 4,000 Indira Awas units every year. The analogy assumes special significance because in Bihar, according to Tendulkar Committee Report, 54.4 per cent of the population is poor. This bitter fact has not missed the attention of Nitish, who

keeps seeking bigger grants from the Centre to alleviate Bihar's poverty.

The Bihar Home Department has received over 50,000 applicants, many of which claimed that they went underground during the agitation. The department maintains that regular monthly honorarium of Rs 2,500 to Rs 5,000 a month will be paid to those who were detained under the Maintenance of Internal Security Act (MISA) or Defence of India Rules during the JP Movement. Spouses of JP Movement participants who were killed in police firing would also get a monthly pension of Rs 5,000. For the injured, the pension will be Rs 2,500. Spouses of those who died in jail would also get a monthly pension of Rs 5,000. The beneficiaries will also get free travel in Bihar State Road Transport Corporation buses, besides free medical facilities.

In the first phase, a committee of ministers headed by Modi has identified 1,686 individuals eligible for pension. "We are about to release the first pension payment," says Bihar Home Secretary Amir Subhani. Since the pension scheme has been made effective from June 2009, the